PODCAST COMPANION · FURMARK HISTORY

The Donut That Cooks GPUs

The story of FurMark: the furry OpenGL donut that stress-tests graphics cards, got treated like a power virus by driver teams, and is still being updated in 2026.

Hosts: Leda & Doral · about 8 minutes · 1191 spoken words
Listen: https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/gh/Parris-Tech-Services/furmark-history@main/site/furmark-history-podcast.mp3
Source files and full research: https://github.com/Parris-Tech-Services/furmark-history
Compiled 13 November 2026 from the developer's own posts and release notes.

About this episode

An eight-minute, two-host walk through FurMark's history: its 2007 beginnings, the 2010 "Hot Like Hell Edition", the years when AMD and NVIDIA built throttling around it, MSI's Kombustor spin-off, and the 2022 to 2026 rebuild as FurMark 2. Voices are synthetic (ElevenLabs); the script was written from the sources listed at the end.

> **How to read the sourcing.** Dates and quotes come from the developer's own Geeks3D posts and changelog wherever possible. Anything that rests on forum reports or on a single secondary source is marked as such in the audio and on the last pages. Nothing here is vendor-confirmed unless it says so.

Episode guide

1. Cold open
2. Seed
3. Hot like hell
4. The power virus years
5. Nvidia joins in
6. Spin-offs and long life
7. A second life
8. Outro

Research: FurMark, a history

Compiled 13 November 2026 from the developer's own posts and release notes, plus independent coverage. Every claim below has a source number in brackets; the list is at the end. Where the evidence is thin, it says so.

The short version

FurMark is a free graphics-card stress test and benchmark. Its signature scene is a rotating, fur-covered torus (the "donut") drawn with OpenGL shaders. The developer says the first version of FurMark 1 was released in **2007** [1]. It was written to push a GPU as hard as possible, mainly so overclockers could check stability [2]. That very quality made driver teams treat it as a "power virus" and throttle cards when it ran [3][4]. FurMark 2, rebuilt on the author's GeeXLab engine, began beta testing on 1 December 2022 [7] and was released publicly in February 2024 [6]. The most recent changelog entry I found is version 2.11.0.4, dated 30 October 2026 [7].

Who made it

FurMark is the work of a developer who goes by **JeGX** (listed as Jérôme Guinot on his early site oZone3D.net, where he wrote OpenGL tutorials) and who later ran **Geeks3D** [1][15]. Geeks3D hosts the official downloads and warns that other sites claiming to be the official page are not [1].

What it actually does

A scene of a furry torus plus a dynamic background (a red/orange background appears in the changelog [7]), rendered in OpenGL, repeating heavy shader maths each frame. It reports an FPS-style score and can read data from GPU-Z when that tool is running [2]. In FurMark 2 the "classic donut" is joined by a "new knot" scene [6]. Beginner guides describe it as a stress test rather than a benchmark, much harsher than any game [16]. I could not confirm, from a primary source, the exact fur-rendering technique, so this document does not claim one.

Timeline

Date	What happened	Source
2007	First version of FurMark 1 released (developer's statement, repeated in 2024 as "more than 16 years ago")	[1][6] [13]
Aug 2008 (approx.)	Catalyst 8.8 adds an AMD protection keyed on the file name `FurMark.exe`, per Geeks3D	[3]
Aug 2009 (approx.)	Catalyst 9.8 improves detection by measuring the ratio of texture to ALU instructions, per Geeks3D	[3]
25 Sep 2009	Geeks3D reports the Radeon HD 5870 (Cypress) has a hardware monitoring chip that throttles one PowerPlay level when the voltage regulators are overloaded	[3]
2 Feb 2010	FurMark 1.8.0 "Hot Like Hell Edition": heat post-effect, vertex-displacement mode for more load, XML localization; scores lower than earlier versions	[2]
19 Apr 2010	FurMark 1.8.2	[2]
9 Nov 2010	GeForce GTX 580 launches with power sensors plus driver detection of FurMark/OCCT; Geeks3D headline: "The Anti-FurMark DX11 Card". TechPowerUp measured 153 W with the limiter, 304 W without	[4]
27 Jan 2011	JeGX comments on a TechPowerUp poll about limiters; objects to Nvidia's being an application blacklist; notes AMD PowerTune is adjustable by about 20%	[5]
Mar 2011	MSI support page describes Kombustor as co-developed by MSI and the FurMark team	[9]
Jun 2011	FurMark 1.8.5 and 1.9.1 (maintenance, newer card support, improved score submission)	[10]
Jun 2011	FurMark used to stress an ASUS ROG GTX 580 at DreamHack, per an oZone3D blog post	[15]
21 Aug 2015	FurMark 1.17.0	[7]
24 Aug 2016	FurMark 1.18.0: GTX 1080/1070/1060 and RX 480/470/460 support, 5K resolution	[7]
1 Dec 2022	FurMark 2.0.0.0, first beta, via the Geeks3D Discord	[7]

Date	What happened	Source
9 Jan 2023	2.0.4.0 adds Linux support	[7]
19 Sep 2023	Press reports FurMark 2 is "launching this month"	[11]
15–24 Feb 2024	FurMark 2.1.0.2 (changelog 15 Feb; release post 24 Feb): Windows 32/64-bit, Linux 64-bit, OpenGL 3.2 and Vulkan 1.1, GUI plus command-line tool, online scores	[6][7] [12]
3 May 2024	2.3.0.0 adds Raspberry Pi 64-bit	[7]
26 Dec 2024	2.5.0.0 adds Intel Arc B580/B570	[7]
2025	Releases track RTX 50-series and Radeon RX 9070 launches	[7]
13 Mar 2025	FurMark 1.39.4: JeGX writes that branch 1.39.x is "probably the last", with only patches until a final stop ("2026?")	[1]
30 Oct 2026	2.11.0.4: new NVIDIA Blackwell GPUs; elapsed time shown as days/hours/minutes/seconds	[7]

The "power virus" years

By Geeks3D's account, the power circuitry on Radeon HD 4850/4870 cards was undersized for FurMark-type loads, so AMD added software protection, first by file name, later by instruction ratio [3]. AnandTech's HD 5970 review lists FurMark and OCCT among AMD's "power virus" programs and accepts the rationale for them [14]. Forum users reported that renaming the executable defeated the early check; I found no vendor confirmation of that, so treat it as unverified [17].

For the GTX 580, TechPowerUp's testing (quoted by Geeks3D) found the limiter engaged only when the driver detected FurMark or OCCT, not in games [4]. JeGX's position in 2011: limiters are acceptable if the user can fully control or disable them, and an application blacklist is not [5].

Things I could not verify

- The **exact fur-rendering technique** (no primary source found).
- Whether renaming the executable really bypassed AMD's early check (forum reports only).
- The **exact first release date** in 2007 (the year is the developer's; the month is not stated in what I read).
- A press article stating the original FurMark "used DirectX": this contradicts every other source (OpenGL) and is not used here.

Sources

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15. oZone3D blog, "FurMark at DreamHack 2011". http://www.ozone3d.net/blogs/lab/downloads/gpu-tools/furmark/
16. Beginner guides that describe it as a stress test rather than a benchmark: Corsair, "How to use FurMark"; Make Tech Easier, "How to Stress Test Your GPU with FurMark". https://www.corsair.com/explorer/gamer/gaming-pcs/how-to-use-furmark
17. Forum reports on early AMD throttling and a renamed executable (anecdotal, unverified): Guru3D thread "radeon hd 4870 overheating". http://forums.guru3d.com/showthread.php?t=360883

Full transcript

Numbers are written the way they are spoken. Quoted phrases are short extracts from the developer's posts.

Cold open

LEDA Picture a furry, rotating donut. Orange fuzz, a flickering background, and a graphics card whose fans are screaming like a hair dryer.

DORAL That donut has made more graphics cards sweat than almost any game ever released.

LEDA Today: FurMark. The free program that exists to make your GPU as hot as possible, on purpose.

DORAL And somehow it ended up detected, throttled and argued over by two of the biggest chip makers on the planet.

Seed

DORAL It starts in two thousand and seven. The author goes by JeGX, Jérôme Guinot. He wrote graphics tutorials on a site called oZone3D, and later ran Geeks3D.

LEDA And his own words, from a post in March twenty twenty-five: the first version of FurMark one was released in two thousand and seven.

DORAL It's built on OpenGL. One scene. A torus covered in fur, drawn with shaders that do an enormous amount of maths on every single frame.

LEDA Why fur? Because fur is brutal to render. It's dense, shader-heavy work that keeps every core busy. Great for hurting a card, useless for playing anything.

DORAL So it was never really a game demo. JeGX pitched it as a stability test. Overclock your card, run the donut, see if it survives.

Hot like hell

LEDA Fast forward to February the second, twenty ten. Version one point eight, with a name that tells you everything: the Hot Like Hell Edition.

DORAL The announcement said, quote, this new version will overheat your GPUs like hell. For a hot winter.

LEDA There was a new effect that simulated a heat haze around the donut. And a displacement mapping effect that made the fur heights uneven, which meant more work for the card.

DORAL He even warned that scores would come out lower than earlier versions, because the workload was heavier.

LEDA And in his own test notes he mentions a Radeon HD forty-eight fifty running a driver, Catalyst nine point five, that, quote, has no protection against FurMark.

DORAL Which is a very strange sentence to read about a benchmark.

The power virus years

LEDA Because protection was the plot twist. Graphics card makers started treating FurMark like malware.

DORAL Here's the story as Geeks3D told it in September two thousand and nine. The power circuitry on the Radeon HD forty-eight fifty and forty-eight seventy cards was, in his words, under-sized for a load like FurMark's.

LEDA So AMD added a protection in Catalyst eight point eight. It looked for the file name: furmark dot exe.

DORAL Rename the file and the throttle went away. At least that's what forum users reported at the time. I couldn't find AMD ever confirming it.

LEDA Then in Catalyst nine point eight, per Geeks3D, the check got smarter. It stopped reading the name and started measuring the ratio of texture work to maths work.

DORAL Smart. Because what do you call a program that deliberately finds the one load a card can't survive?

LEDA The industry called it a power virus. AnandTech's review of the Radeon HD fifty-nine seventy says FurMark and OCCT were on AMD's list.

DORAL JeGX was not thrilled. He wrote that for a card costing two hundred dollars or more, quote, I should have the right to draw some furry objects.

LEDA With the next generation, the Radeon HD fifty-eight seventy, AMD moved the protection into hardware. A small monitoring chip watching the voltage regulators, throttling one performance step when things got dangerous.

Nvidia joins in

DORAL Then November two thousand and ten. Nvidia launches the GeForce GTX five-eighty, and Geeks3D's headline is: the Anti-FurMark card.

LEDA Three sensors on the twelve-volt lines measured power. And the driver watched for FurMark or OCCT running.

DORAL When it detected one, the card clocked itself down. Not in games, only in the stress tests. Nvidia said it was protecting cards and motherboards.

LEDA The reviewer at TechPowerUp measured it. A hundred and fifty-three watts with the limiter. Three hundred and four without.

DORAL Half the power. In the one program people used to measure power.

LEDA Reviewers were stuck, because FurMark was how they tested temperatures, noise and power draw. Suddenly the donut wasn't telling the whole truth.

DORAL In January twenty eleven, JeGX picked up on a TechPowerUp reader poll about these limiters. The majority said they were fine with them, but only with full control to switch them off.

LEDA He put himself in that majority. His complaint about Nvidia's version was that it was based on, quote, an applications blacklist. Which, he wrote, really sucks.

DORAL He added that AMD's PowerTune at least let you adjust the limit by about twenty percent. And that Asus had left the limiter off its GTX five-sixty Ti, so FurMark ran at full speed.

Spin-offs and long life

DORAL Meanwhile FurMark became a standard. Geeks3D describes MSI's Kombustor as a burn-in tool, quote, based on the well-known FurMark software. MSI's own support page from twenty eleven says it was co-developed by MSI and the FurMark team.

LEDA A blog post by JeGX has FurMark at DreamHack in June twenty eleven, stressing an Asus ROG GTX five-eighty on the show floor.

DORAL And the old version just kept shipping. One point seventeen in August twenty fifteen. One point eighteen a year later, adding GTX ten-eighty and RX four-eighty support, plus a five-K resolution.

LEDA Over the years it went from fighting drivers to being listed in every guide on how to test a new build.

DORAL A caution that every guide repeats, though: it's a stress test, much harsher than any game. Treat the temperature numbers with respect.

A second life

LEDA December the first, twenty twenty-two. Version two point zero point zero point zero. A beta, handed out to the Geeks3D Discord.

DORAL Rebuilt on JeGX's own GeeXLab engine. Linux support arrived in January twenty twenty-three. Vulkan alongside OpenGL.

LEDA The public launch came in February twenty twenty-four. Version two point one. In the release notes JeGX wrote, quote, FurMark two is finally there. It took me more time than expected.

DORAL It supports OpenGL three point two and Vulkan one point one, on Windows and Linux, with a command line tool and a graphical front end.

LEDA There's a new scene too: a twisted knot, next to the classic donut. And online scores, so you can compare your card with everyone else's.

DORAL Since then, updates have followed new hardware almost like a diary. A Raspberry Pi build in May twenty twenty-four. Intel Arc Battlemage support that December. Nvidia RTX fifty-series cards in twenty twenty-five.

LEDA The most recent entry I found is version two point eleven, dated October the thirtieth, twenty twenty-six. It adds new Nvidia Blackwell chips, and shows elapsed time as days, hours, minutes and seconds.

DORAL The changelog says that's handy for very long stress test sessions.

LEDA And the old version? In March twenty twenty-five JeGX wrote that FurMark one's branch one point thirty-nine was probably the last. Only patches after that, until a final stop, he wrote, maybe in twenty twenty-six.

Outro

DORAL So that's FurMark. A program written to be unreasonable, that forced two chip giants to build safety nets into their hardware.

LEDA And still, nearly twenty years on, one fuzzy donut is how a lot of us decide whether a graphics card is ready to be trusted.

DORAL Check your temperatures. Keep the fans clean.

LEDA And if your card ever starts clocking down the moment you launch the donut, now you know why.

DORAL Thanks for listening.

Generated from the repository. Spoken audio: ElevenLabs, voices Laura and Charlie, model Turbo v2.5.